

Semantics and Pragmatics (ENG508)

Definition of Semantics and Pragmatics

- **Semantics:** the study of meaning in language, focusing on the meaning of words, phrases, sentences, and texts.
- **Pragmatics:** the study of how language is used in context to communicate effectively, considering factors like speaker intention, audience, and social norms.

 **The Borderline between Semantics and Pragmatics:** The distinction between semantics and pragmatics can be blurry, as meaning is often dependent on context.

Sentence and Utterance

- **Sentence:** a unit of language that expresses a complete thought or idea.
- **Utterance:** a specific instance of a sentence being used in a particular context.

 **Language and Logic:** Language and logic are closely related, as language is used to express logical ideas and relationships.

The Explicit and the Implicit

- **Explicit meaning:** the literal or obvious meaning of a sentence or text.
- **Implicit meaning:** the implied or suggested meaning that goes beyond the literal interpretation.

 **Semantics in Linguistics:** Semantics is a key area of study in linguistics, exploring how meaning is created and conveyed through language.

 **Semantics in a Model of Grammar:** A model of grammar that includes semantics aims to explain how meaning is generated from the structure of language.

 **Historical Semantics:** Historical semantics examines how word meanings change over time.

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✚ **Semantics in Other Disciplines:** Semantics is also relevant in fields like philosophy, computer science, and anthropology.

✚ **Semantics and Semiotics:** Semiotics is the study of signs and symbols, and semantics is a key part of this field.

✚ **Reference and Sense**

- **Reference:** the relationship between a word or phrase and the thing it refers to.
- **Sense:** the meaning of a word or phrase in a particular context.

✚ **Utterance, Sentence and Proposition**

- **Utterance:** a specific instance of a sentence being used.
- **Sentence:** a unit of language that expresses a complete thought.
- **Proposition:** the meaning or idea expressed by a sentence.

✚ **Utterance, Sentence and Proposition -Activities:** These terms are related to how language is used to communicate and convey meaning.

✚ **Literal and Non-Literal Meaning**

- **Literal meaning:** the obvious or explicit meaning of a sentence or text.
- **Non-literal meaning:** the implied or suggested meaning that goes beyond the literal interpretation.

✚ **Semantics and Pragmatics:** Semantics focuses on the meaning of language, while pragmatics considers how language is used to communicate effectively.

✚ **Meaning Holism -Meaning within Language:** Meaning holism suggests that meaning is not just a matter of individual words or phrases, but of the entire language system.

✚ **Idea Theory of Meaning:** This theory posits that meaning is based on the ideas or concepts that words and phrases represent.

✚ **Meanings Are out in the World:** This perspective suggests that meaning is not just a matter of language, but of the world and our experiences in it.

✚ **Meaning of Sentences and Truth Condition:** The meaning of a sentence is closely tied to its truth condition, or the circumstances under which it is true.

✚ **Putting Meaning Together from Pieces – Compositional Theory:** This theory suggests that meaning is composed of smaller parts, such as words and phrases, that combine to create the meaning of a sentence or text.

✚ **KINDS OF MEANING**

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- **Linguistic/Conceptual Meaning:** the meaning of words and phrases based on their linguistic structure and conceptual relationships.
- **Connotative/Referential Meaning:** the emotional or associative meaning of words (connotative) versus their literal reference (referential).
- **Social Meaning:** the meaning derived from social context, norms, and relationships.
- **Affective Meaning:** the emotional or attitudinal meaning of words and phrases.
- **Reflective and Collocative Meaning:** the meaning derived from the relationship between words and their contexts (collocative) and the reflection of meaning back on the speaker (reflective).
- **Thematic Meaning:** the underlying theme or idea conveyed by a text or discourse.

MEANING, THOUGHT AND REALITY

- **Sense and Concepts:** the meaning of words and phrases is related to the concepts they represent.
- **Necessary and Sufficient Conditions:** the conditions under which a word or phrase applies to a concept or object.
- **Prototypes:** the central, typical instances of a concept or category.
- **Linguistic Relativity:** the idea that language influences thought and perception.
- **The Language of Thought Hypothesis:** the idea that thought is conducted in a mental language.

What are Lexical Relations?

Lexical relations refer to the relationships between words and their meanings, including:

- Synonyms (words with similar meanings)
- Antonyms (words with opposite meanings)
- Hyponyms (words with more specific meanings)
- Meronyms (words with part-whole relationships)
- Causative verbs and agentive nouns (words that express cause-and-effect relationships)

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- Colour terms (words that describe colours)

✚ **Words and Lexical Items:** Words are the basic units of language, while lexical items are the specific instances of words in context.

✚ **Problems with Pinning Down Word Meaning**

Word meaning can be difficult to define due to:

- Homonymy (words with multiple meanings)
- Polysemy (words with related meanings)
- Contextual variation
- Semantic change over time

✚ **LEXICAL SEMANTICS: FIELDS AND COLLOCATION**

- **Pragmatic and Syntagmatic Relations:** the relationships between words based on their use in context (pragmatic) and their grammatical relationships (syntagmatic).
- **Semantic Fields:** the areas of meaning that words and concepts occupy, such as "food" or "emotions".
- **Collocations:** the common combinations of words that occur together, such as "strong coffee" or "happy birthday".
- **Idioms:** fixed expressions with non-literal meanings, such as "kick the bucket" or "break a leg".

✚ **PRESUPPOSITION**

- **Two Approaches to Presupposition:** the semantic approach (focusing on meaning) and the pragmatic approach (focusing on use in context).
- **Presupposition Failure:** when a presupposition is not met, leading to a breakdown in communication.
- **Presupposition Triggers:** words or phrases that trigger presuppositions, such as "again" or "still".
- **Presupposition and Context:** how presuppositions interact with the surrounding context to affect meaning.

✚ **Classifying Situations**

- **Tense and Aspect:** the grammatical categories that express time and duration, such as past, present, and future.
- **Modality:** the expression of possibility, necessity, and obligation, using words like "can", "must", and "should".

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- **Mood:** the expression of attitude or emotion, such as indicative, imperative, or subjunctive.
- **Evidentiality:** the expression of evidence or source of information, such as "I saw it" or "I heard it".

Classifying Participants

The study of how participants are classified and referred to in language, including:

- **Agent** (the doer of the action)
- **Patient** (the recipient of the action)
- **Theme** (the thing affected by the action)
- **Goal** (the intended target of the action)

Thematic Roles: (Beneficiary, Instrument, Location, Goal, Source, Stimulus)

- **Agent:** the entity that performs the action
- **Patient:** the entity that receives the action
- **Theme:** the entity that is affected by the action
- **Experiencer:** the entity that experiences the action
- **Beneficiary:** the entity that benefits from the action
- **Instrument:** the entity used to perform the action
- **Location:** the place where the action occurs
- **Goal:** the intended target of the action
- **Source:** the origin of the action
- **Stimulus:** the entity that triggers the action

 **Identifying Thematic Roles:** Identifying the thematic roles of entities in a sentence helps to understand the relationships between them and the action described.

 **Problems with Thematic Roles:** Thematic roles can be difficult to identify, especially in complex sentences or with ambiguous words.

 **Formal Grammar:** Formal grammar is the study of the underlying structure of language, using mathematical and logical techniques.

 **Grammatical Categories:** Grammatical categories are the basic classes of words and phrases, such as nouns, verbs, and adjectives.

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- ✚ **Grammar and Lexicon:** Grammar refers to the rules governing the structure of language, while lexicon refers to the words and their meanings.
- ✚ **Grammatical Relations:** Grammatical relations are the relationships between words and phrases in a sentence, such as subject-verb-object.
- ✚ **Case Grammar:** Case grammar is a theoretical framework that analyzes the grammatical relations between entities in a sentence.
- ✚ **Diversity within Formal Semantics:** Formal semantics encompasses various approaches and theories, including model-theoretic semantics and type-theoretic semantics.
- ✚ **Relationship with other Varieties of Semantics:** Formal semantics interacts with other areas of semantics, such as lexical semantics and compositional semantics.
- ✚ **Relationship with other Fields:** Semantics draws on insights from philosophy, psychology, anthropology, and computer science.
- ✚ **Semantics and Society:** Semantics has implications for understanding language use in social contexts and power dynamics.
- ✚ **Practical Dictionary:** A practical dictionary is a reference work that provides information on word meanings and usage.
- ✚ **Theoretical Dictionary:** A theoretical dictionary is a hypothetical reference work that provides a systematic and comprehensive account of word meanings.
- ✚ **Lexical Rules (Graded Accessibility):** Lexical rules describe how words are used and combined, with graded accessibility referring to the varying degrees of acceptability.
- ✚ **Types of Lexical Rules:** Lexical rules can be classified into different types, such as selectional restrictions and collocational restrictions.
- ✚ **Other Observations about Lexical Rules:** Lexical rules can be context-dependent and subject to exceptions and variations.
- ✚ **What is Pragmatics?** Pragmatics is the study of how language is used in context to communicate effectively.
- ✚ **Types of Pragmatics:** Pragmatics encompasses various subfields, including sociopragmatics, psychopragmatics, and computational pragmatics.

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- ✚ **What Does Pragmatics Study?** Pragmatics examines how speakers use language to achieve communicative goals, considering factors like context, inference, and implicature.
- ✚ **Pragmatics and Linguistics:** Pragmatics draws on insights from linguistics, philosophy, and psychology to understand language use.
- ✚ **The Emergence of Pragmatics as a Distinct Field:** Pragmatics developed as a distinct field in the 1970s, building on earlier work in linguistics and philosophy.
- ✚ **Development and Expansion of Pragmatics:** Pragmatics has continued to evolve, incorporating new approaches and applications, such as computational pragmatics and experimental pragmatics.
- ✚ **Pragmatics and Ordinary Language:** Pragmatics studies how language is used in everyday communication, focusing on the role of context and inference.
- ✚ **Pragmatics:** Pragmatics is a subfield of linguistics that examines how speakers use language to achieve communicative goals.
- ✚ **The Prehistory of Pragmatics:** The study of pragmatics has its roots in ancient philosophy, particularly in the works of Aristotle and the Stoics.
- ✚ **Modern Pragmatics:** Modern pragmatics emerged in the 1970s, influenced by linguistics, philosophy, and anthropology.
- ✚ **Context and Pragmatics:** Context plays a crucial role in pragmatics, as it helps disambiguate language and infer intended meaning.
- ✚ **Situational Context:** Situational context refers to the physical and social environment in which communication takes place.
- ✚ **Background Knowledge Context:** Background knowledge refers to the shared knowledge and assumptions that speakers bring to a conversation.
- ✚ **Co-textual Context:** Co-textual context refers to the linguistic context in which a sentence or utterance appears.
- ✚ **Exploring Context:** Pragmatics explores how context influences language use and meaning, including reference, inference, and implicature.
- ✚ **Reference:** Reference refers to the relationship between language and the world, including how speakers use language to refer to objects, events, and concepts.

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- ✚ **Referring to the Context Outside:** Exophora: Exophora refers to the use of language to refer to the external context, such as pointing to an object.
- ✚ **Referring to the Context Inside:** Cohesion: Cohesion refers to the use of language to create links between elements within a text or conversation.
- ✚ **Grammatical Cohesion:** Grammatical cohesion refers to the use of grammatical structures, such as pronouns and conjunctions, to create links between clauses.
- ✚ **Lexical Cohesion:** Lexical cohesion refers to the use of vocabulary to create links between elements within a text or conversation.
- ✚ **Observing the Maxims:** The cooperative principle, proposed by Paul Grice, states that speakers should be truthful, informative, relevant, and clear in their communication.
- ✚ **Flouting the Maxims:** Flouting the maxims refers to the intentional violation of the cooperative principle, often to achieve a specific communicative goal.
- ✚ **Violating the Maxims:** Violating the maxims refers to the unintentional or accidental violation of the cooperative principle.
- ✚ **Limitations of the Cooperative Principles:** The cooperative principle has limitations, as speakers may prioritize other goals, such as politeness or humor, over the maxims.